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They Are Us

Perth Arena, Perth, Australia

From that point on, I was desperate to get on the plane. Danni, Emma, the rookies... I was tired of thinking about this event, and I wanted to get the show on the road. More than that, I wanted to give in to this power Danni held over me. While the suddenness of it still stunned me, I was equally amazed by the tenacity with which it held onto me. It was like some emotional scale had finally tipped, and fighting against it was exhausting me.

Once I got on the plane, though, it wasn't long before I was reminded of how unbearable these flights to Australia are. Private or commercial, it doesn't matter. It's torture. If teleportation doesn't become a thing soon, I'm going to kill someone.

Though we'd reached our destination nearly twenty-four hours earlier, I was only just starting to mellow when we arrived at the arena for the rookie event. Being stuffed into the tiny manager's office that hung off the locker room didn't help. Having Danni with me did.

Two hours before the opening bell, Steph walked in with a scowl on her face and a ragged scrap of paper in her hand. She flipped it down in front of me without a word.

I immediately recognizing the hurried scrawl of her handwriting, and one glance told me why she was annoyed.

Cameron-Russell
Holt-Walcott
Coleman-Grace

The random pairings had been announced, and all three of our fighters had gotten the short straw shoved straight up her ass.

Common-sense said Steph had written the information down in the order in which she'd received it. Random chance had caused her to also write it so that the news got worse as I went along.

Dove had drawn Keri Russell - a fighter with seven fights under her belt. Like many in this league, she had gotten into the MMA game a little later on in life. No matter. They say that age is just a number, and Keri's record certainly bore that out. Five dominant victories - three by unanimous decision and two by submission - with two close decision losses scattered in. Lacking in power, her technique was rock solid. She needed time and patience to set up the finish, so Dove was likely to have plenty of time to settle in. But it also meant she was in for a long night if she couldn't seize control of the action.

Like Russell, Jennifer Walcott was on the older side. Unlike Keri, her MMA career had started horrendously. Two terrible submission losses marked her as an easy target, and it looked like she was done before she even got going. But Walcott wasn't having it. She committed herself to correcting the problem, and has since rattled off six wins in a row - all by knockout or stoppage. Her submission defense was now top-of-the-line for someone with her experience. Her striking game was dangerous but unpolished, and she's known for trading defensive posture to generate more power. An important flaw that would be of no use if she knocked Liv stupid before she could exploit it.

Jillian Grace was a product of the same stable that had introduced the MMA world to Cheryl Cole. Her nine fights of experience put her at the limit for the rookie designation, which made her look like a grizzled veteran up against the winless Zendaya. The worst-case scenario. Worse than worst-case because Daya's performances had been mostly terrible, while Jillian's had been breath-taking. Nine fights. Nine knockout victories. Her striking game was precise and her power was unbelievable. Did she have weaknesses? Probably, but no one knew what they were because there was hardly any film to study. None of her fights had lasted more than thirty seconds.

Raw power, put to work in unrelenting, overwhelming fashion. Sound like someone we know?

If Cheryl Cole truly was the rightful queen she thought she was, then Jillian Grace was the princess in waiting. Gorgeous looks, fearsome power and a spotless record... she was the kind of living, breathing marketing strategy that had the league execs drooling all over each other. And poor Zendaya looked like nothing more than a speed bump on her way to a perfect ten for ten in the win column.

Danni read the list over my shoulder, muttered the word *fuck*, then looked at Steph.

"Do they know?"

Steph nodded.

"It went up on the league site two minutes ago. They'd been waiting. Watching it like hawks."

Danni straightened up and started for the door.

"They're back with Marcy," Steph said. "Tiz and Emma are there, too."

Danni nodded and then she was gone. The stable leader on a mission.

As for me... given the circumstances, I think a minor fit would have been justified. My stable had just gotten the royal shaft times three. By random chance, of course.

But there was no upside to screaming and yelling. The matchups were set. No point in getting worked up over something I couldn't change. Win or lose, I expected my fighters to act like pros. No reason I couldn't do that, too.

I raised my gaze to Steph.

"Odds?"

Her eyes drifted right as she did a mental calculation using a formula of her own creation. I didn't know how it worked or what the variables were. I only knew it had proven pretty accurate in the past.

The eyes came back to me as she arrived at her results.

"Holt and Cameron... I'd say seventy-thirty in their favor. Coleman... fifty-fifty."

My jaw fell open.

"This is not the time for you to suddenly discover the power of positive thought, Steph. I need to know what they're up against."

"You know exactly what they're up against. It's Russell, Walcott and Grace that are in for a surprise."

I felt an urge to call out for Trish. Steph was obviously having a stroke.

"You're giving Daya even odds against Jillian Grace?"

"I was tempted to give her the edge, but I didn't want to get overconfident."

I blinked a few times, then studied my hands as I flexed my fingers. Checking my motor control. Worried that maybe I was the one having the stroke.

"Even money?" I asked again. "Against the Golden Child?"

"Have you been watching them at all?"

"The rookies? Sure, and it's given me a good feeling about their future. I think they've really settled in, and the way they've bonded with their teammates has been great. But..."

"It's been much more than bonding," she said.

I decided it was time to shut up for a second and examine the situation. Steph was our training guru for a reason. She knew how to motivate. How to teach. How to keep her charges focused. And she knew how to spot trouble. When that happened, she told me. She told Danni. And she never tried to frame it. She just told it like it was, and then we discussed solutions.

This was the opposite of that. If she was to be believed, then things in the training area had been going even better than I ever could have imagined. And why would I not believe her? This is what I paid her for, and she was good at it. She knew her fighters, and she knew what they were capable of. And she appeared to be of sound mind and body. So...

"Even odds?" I asked one more time.

She nodded.

"Seventy-thirty?" I asked.

Another nod.

"Well, alright then," I concluded. "Let's go get 'em ready."

I emerged from the office prepared to give a big speech. To motivate the older fighters and get them ready to pick up the rookies.

I was too late.

I had to walk a long way before I found anyone. All the way back to the trainer's area. And when I got there, everything was already in motion.

Dove was in room one, surrounded by Julianne Hough, Kristen Bell and Jen Morrison. The bantamweight sisterhood was out in force. They were a ragtag bunch, comprised of some of the scrappiest and most determined fighters I'd ever seen. Winning did not come easy to most of them, but they didn't seem to mind taking the hard way. What they lacked in skill and ability they more than made up for in resiliency. Anyone who got in the cage with one of them knew to expect a war.

The only one who didn't fit the pattern was the very polished Jules, but that didn't make her an outlier. Just the opposite. It made her the centerpiece. With a divisional belt and a few tournament titles in her trophy case, she was the one the others looked to. But I don't think it was the awards that really mattered to her teammates. Long before she established herself among the elite, Jules showed the world exactly what kind of heart beat in her chest. Her raging battles with Vikki Blows were the stuff of lore. Even the rookies had heard the legendary tales of their bloody, knock-down, drag-out, last-woman-standing brawls.

So, go ahead. Let her fool you. Buy into the flirty hair and the sickeningly sunny disposition. But mark my words... cross Julianne Hough at your own peril. And don't be surprised if you have no memory of how you ended up on your ass.

It was that well-deserved reputation that earned Jules the respect of her fellow fighters, and she was putting that cachet to good use now. Though Dove looked a little worried, you could almost see the way Jules - with her calm, intelligent, blue eyes - was sponging those fears away and replacing them with a steady confidence. Like Dove was starting to realize she could do this, simply because Julianne said she could.

Liv was in room two, sitting on the table with her arm straight out in front of her as Marcy did her thing. Tiz - the remaining member of the *Bantamweight Brigade*, and maybe the gutsiest of them all - was standing beside her, with Emma manning the other flank. Leading the conversation from the head of the table was

Danni. I couldn't hear what she was saying, but she looked perfectly normal. No panic. No urgency. Like they were discussing the weather, or the pros and cons of purchasing travel insurance before a big trip.

I lost sight of them when Aly rounded through the doorway, clapping her hands and shouting.

"C'mon baby! We got this! We GOT this!"

We. Like they were all in this together.

Daya was in room three, surrounded by her middleweight teammates. Britney and Stana Katic on the left. Leesh and J-Law to the right. All eyes were focused on Emily VanCamp, standing at the end of the table. Again, though I was too far away for her words to reach me, I could see her everyday, even-keeled nature in the way she was moving. No stress or pressure. Just the facts. Same as Danni. Same as Jules.

There was a message in their common temperament, and it was the same one Aly had voiced.

We got this.

Everyone else was milling around. Shouting. Clapping. Showing support. One came out, one went in. Flowing from room to room with the precision of a single organism.

Random or not, the results of the draw had come across as an attack on the RSI rookies, and the whole roster was responding. Maybe they still had to carry the bags. Maybe they hadn't earned TV privileges on the team plane. But make no mistake... *they* were us. And you don't fuck with us.

Steph and I watched the parade in silence for a while.

"Sixty-forty for Coleman," she concluded firmly. "It's not overconfident."